only to sustain a certain level of chaos in the state and not find a solution to it. Rajiv Gandhi had also started associating with this think-tank's activities and influencing its decisions when a higher-level consultation was required. On occasion, when the situation in Punjab appeared to be worsening, the think-tank, on behalf of the Central government, took some administrative measures. These included suspension of the Punjab government, change of governor and DGP, posting of some advisors, and a show of (and not use of) force, to reassure the Hindus that the government was not insensitive to their growing concerns.

As desired, the impact of such measures was transient, and the situation would eventually return to its previous – if not higher – level of turmoil. In short, Punjab was like a pressure cooker whose temperature control, to maintain the right amount of pressure, was in the hands of the above-mentioned three-man think-tank working under the close supervision and guidance of Indira Gandhi, assisted by Rajiv Gandhi who was himself under the influence of others, including Makhan Lal Fotedar and Arun Nehru.

The 'killer Squad' and unabated violence

While Harchand Singh Longowal and other Akali leaders were fast losing credibility, Bhindranwale did not miss any opportunity to criticize them for their weak-kneed attitude towards the Central government. By then he had built a team of trusted lieutenants to help manage his various activities. The team included Harminder Singh Sandhu, general secretary of the All India Sikh Students Federation (AISSF), Dalbir Singh, his political advisor, and Rachpal Singh, his secretary. His right-hand man, Amrik Singh, president of AISSF, and his second-in-command, Thara Singh, who had been arrested on 19 July 1982, resumed their activities after their release in the summer of 1983**.**

Lest anyone should refuse to accept his authority, Bhindranwale constituted a 'killer squad'. That comprised, among others, four deserters from Punjab police (Amarjit Singh, Sewa Singh, Kabul Singh and Gurnam Singh), an escaped convict, Talwinder Singh, and Surinder Singh Sodhi. [1] Bhindranwale also started holding